texturen
Nr. 9 – *Schmucken*

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Herausgebende der Reihe	Thomas Düllo Konstantin Haensch Johanna Kirschbauer
Herausgebende des Bandes	Melanie Isverding Konstantin Haensch Thomas Düllo Karin Deckner
Bildstrecken	Lara Köhler
Gestaltung, Layout, Satz	Mara-Laurin Lübke Miriam Pujiula Buhl Bastian Otto

Logos Verlag Berlin
λογος

Logos Verlag Berlin GmbH
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Avoiding Unnecessary Harm: Craft in Service of the Master's End

matt lambert

Content warning for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people – this essay contains images and names of people who have died.

For as much as I seem to wander whenever I look back, jewellery always seems to be there. The learning of jewellery as a dialect of craft discourse has provided a way to 'look with'. Beyond its physicality, jewellery provides many conceptual tools and a positioning of materiality I have come to see as invaluable to grappling with and challenging the many confines and segregating borders that power structures such as colonialism and capitalism have fabricated. It is a focus on connection, setting and relating to another human body as well as my own. I have reached this perspective through a complex amalgamation of experiences and mentorship. Unpacking how this perspective has developed requires looking back at the positioning of craft, and its role in shaping the world. The mapping of some of this is what I am attempting to do here while knowing it is incomplete.



Fig. 1: Cornelis Cort, *De smidse van de cyclopen* (The cyclopes' Forge), 1572, Attribution: Rijks Museum, The Netherlands, Public Domain

The definitions of craft and jewellery are vast and diverse. Slippery terms that seem to shift based on the conditions of their deployment. One framing of craft I have been fond of working with is Iftikhar Dadi's in his editorial introduction to Prince Claus Fund Journal #10, *The Future Is Handmade, The Survival and Innovation of Crafts*:

What is 'craft'? The word has a complex history and equally complex associations [...] Crafting is a material process, as a skill by which a material product is created, but also as an immaterial skill or practice by which a service is offered [...] Indeed, crafts today can be seen as a medium through which some of the most significant issues of contemporary life are articulated. (2003: 4–5)

Excerpted from a larger and specific addressing of the journal's content, I was and am intrigued by the word 'service'. Service to whom and for what, who decides this service and its value? Service implies an action, and by some of the many definitions of service in the Oxford Dictionary (2025) removes the making

of something physical altogether. Service defined as:

an act of carrying out work or rendering assistance of a particular kind for a customer, client, etc., but which is not (primarily) concerned with the manufacture of a commodity or the sale of goods" or "the action or fact of helping or benefiting someone or something; action or behavior that is conducive to the welfare or advantage of another; help, assistance.

It is these types of definitions I fear are constantly being hidden in an attempt to forget. Craft and, from my biased position, metalsmithing/jewellery have played significant roles in shaping histories, in connecting people and in making, changing and destroying worlds. So many craft education programs in universities focus on the object as the work, a focus that becomes more anxious daily for the rising urgency of conversations around material usage and extraction in relation to environmental sustainability. Do we need new physical objects to make new meanings? When studio crafted objects become "a material" in craft discourse instead of "the complete work" the ground starts to radically shift. Making the awareness of how craft has been framed and how craftspeople have had specific narratives bestowed on them all the more important. It is from this awareness that we can reflect and step away from this construction and see what other possibilities and potentials arise. Craft is power, it is the ability to connect and communicate with others, it is the movement and use of material and what happens along its paths as it cruises (lambert). Craft is not on a binary with art or on a scale of good and bad, it is how it has and is used that places craft in these circumstances of judgement.



Fig. 2: *Hephaistos and Cyclops forging Achilles' shield for Thetis*, n.d. Greco-Roman bas-relief marble, from the Pinacoteca Capitolina, Palazzo Conservatori, Rome, Italy Attribution: Capitoline Museums, Public Domain

The role of the craftsperson has been essential in the building of civilizations. Holding the knowledge of making the literal cornerstones of structures. In Greek and Roman myth which seems to dominate cultural mythology in mainstream Westernized visual media, Hephaistos in Greek or Vulcan in Roman mythology is the god of the forge, known as a craftsman/builder and is either the son of Hera, goddess of marriage, women, and family and Zeus, the chief deity of the Pantheon of gods. Or he is the son of Hera alone depending on the source.

Hephaistos "plays the role of the marvelous craftsman, building places and fashioning wonderous objects for the gods" (Hansen 2004: 46) including Zeus's iconic symbol of power *The Keraunos or Master Bolt*. He is also credited for crafting the first women from clay (ibid: 151) and teaching mankind craft skills.

Hephaistos is not the only god associated with craft, as there are several goddesses such as Athena associated with handcraft. However, he is the only prominent male god in a patriarchal culture associated with craft. For all Hephaistos did for the gods' benefit he was also capable of crafting objects to restrain them. He forges an invisible net to trap his wife Aphrodite while having an affair with Ares and inviting all the other gods to witness the adultery and a chair with invisible bonds to restrain his mother Hera and refuses to release her (ibid: 162).

Hephaistos has a narrative that makes him invaluable to the gods. Making tools essential for their use, symbolizing their power and authority. He is also one of the gods to teach mankind the skills needed to survive and flourish, celebrated as an icon and champion of progress and civilization (Morford et al. 2011: 24). A god of such recognized skill and power causes one to wonder why he is not in the position of Zeus. However, Hephaistos lacks one attribute, beauty. He is physically lame due to a congenital impairment, motivating his own mother Hera to cast him off Mount Olympus, his reason to trap her in a chair (Hansen 2004: 162). Or in another account he is made lame from Zeus throwing him off Mount Olympus to protect Hera from his advances. He works at his forge with the Cyclops, one-eyed characters who are so gruesome when born it is attempted to shove them back up into their mother's womb (Morford et al. 2011). To possess Intellect, physical skill and beauty as a man in a patriarchal structure would create a force that would be capable of overthrowing Zeus himself. Instead, Hephaistos and the Cyclopes are forced to only create beauty while never being seen as beautiful themselves. A narrative that keeps the craftsperson in the role of service for others' power and not of their own.

Hephaistos is not the only god of craft who is disfigured in some way. Ptah the Egyptian creator god and patron god of

craftsmen, conceives the world and in some stories creates all the other gods, has green skin, is dwarfish with a misshapen body (Mahran and Kamal). Wayland the Germanic god of the smith who was maimed by a king who held him captive is "the weird and malicious craftsman" (Weston 1929: 841). The Ugarit god Kothar-wa-Khasis also known as Kothar is known as an architect, smith and magician who uses his skill for other gods and is recognized by his abnormal distinctive walk. The smith god of Japan is called "The One-Eyed God of the Sky" (Eliade 1978: 104). Some scholarly writing interprets these physical ailments as reflections of the toll physical labor and the toxic nature of some substances used in craft processes take on the human body (Moffett 2018). A sacrifice to hold the knowledge and skill to create for the bettering of humankind but also for the service of those in power, crafting the tools needed to control, conquer and destroy as they please.



Fig. 3: Bronze Foundry Painter, Attic Red-figure bowl: so-called "ore-foundry bowl" Kylix (vessel shape / bowl). Digitized detail of interior tondo depicting: Hephaestus hands in the new Achilles' armor to Thetis. Attic red-figure Kylix, 490–480 BC

The thoughtfully designed, "well-made", functional object for harmless domestic use does not escape being used by those in power for control. Venues such as national museums, and world's fairs are usually supported by government funding with the stated mission of promoting their countries or a global region's culture can be seen as grey propaganda. Building national narratives to project to visiting tourists, and packaging and sending around the world to display a desired narrative. As Per Unckel, Secretary General of the Nordic Council of Ministers 1986 – 1991 states in the preface for *Scandinavian Design Beyond the Myth* about the term "Scandinavian Design", "this may have been a fiction that suited the rest of the world but it was also a fiction, which suited the North, especially the Nordic manufacturers" allowing for objects to become "icons" (5). Motivated by economic growth or to construct specific national narratives, craft objects become in service of creating national identities, drawing specific lines of what is and is not, what does and does not fit in. As Mirjam Gelfer-Jørgensen highlights within the same book Scandinavianism "was originally an ideological and political movement", a "movement that only developed along with the emergence of the nation state" (17). Maintaining the identity of the nation state is still seen today, an example being seen in Sweden at *Nationalmuseum* in Stockholm. A museum that collects contemporary craft and design for a national narrative, while only a short walk down the street objects deemed to be art (usually by what university education is listed on a degree) are collected by Moderna Museet, the modern and contemporary art museum. Allowing for Swedish and Nordic art to be seen alongside and equal to artwork coming from elsewhere.

This construction and manipulation of national identity through domestic and everyday objects is global. Academic Chunmei Li in *Crafting Modern China: The Revival of Yixing*

Pottery, points to how "in China, craft has been the object of powerful ideological manipulation," once considered "individualistic and bourgeois by the State authorities, to a propaganda vector for a *'new socialism'*" (221). Academic Paul Greenough in *Nation, Economy, and Tradition Displayed: The Indian Craft Museum, New Delhi* states in regard to India:

The museum has been successful in continuing to link the idea of the unity of the nation with certain preindustrial technologies and associated rituals. The idea of a single religiously necessary and perennial Indian craft tradition, [...] is demonstrably a nationalist myth (243).

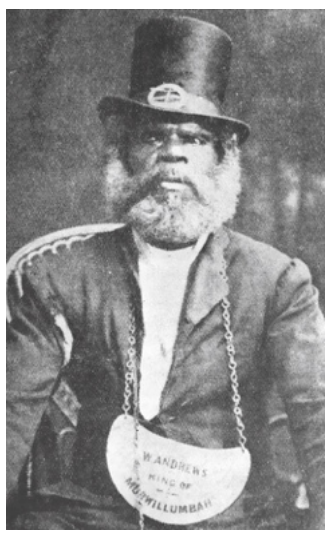




Fig. 4: Daniel Marquis. *Man Wearing Breastplate Inscribed, King Sandy* – Brisbane, 1864-1869. N.d., Attribution: State Library of Queensland, Australia.

Fig. 5: Unknown. *Billy Andrews from the Tweed River Region*. N.d., Attribution: State Library of Queensland, Australia Public Domain

As contemporary/art/author jewellery is younger than most institutionally siloed areas of craft there is not enough work as compared to others being done or contextualized in ways to be considered part of the discourse. Jewellery is often the only area of concentration in universities that is not defined by its material. Some institutions have changed their names from 'metalsmithing' or 'metal' to 'jewellery', which fuels my interest in discussing jewellery as a field, format, concept, or discipline and the drive for authorship. Often work such as precious fine jewellery much like that worn by royals is rejected as part of the contemporary conversation whether by wanting to separate from what could be viewed as concept-less capitalism or to avoid narratives such as that of the blood diamond. In these narratives jewellery becomes the physical symbol of violent power, unavoidably tied to colonialism and imperialism.

I first encountered Aboriginal Breastplates also referred to as Kingplates at the National Museum of Australia in Canberra as a research fellow at Australian National University. Upon seeing these objects, I immersed myself as much as possible in archival material at ATSIDA the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Archive. I discuss here with gratitude to ATSIDA and the Tweed Regional Museum in Murwillumbah for sending me a catalogue of *Aboriginal Breastplates of the Northern Rivers: Contested Recognition, Uncontested Identity* – the only exhibition focusing on these objects that was known at that time. Only a small portion of information I respectfully share here with consent, motivated to build awareness while acknowledging my lack of expertise.

Kingplates get their form from 'gorgets', the part of medieval armor that protected the throat. "Gorgets similar to breastplates were also worn in the 18th century by Native Americans and also by Indigenous people of some Pacific Island nations" (Kean 2016: 2). The credit for introducing Kingplates

to the land (Australia) is given to Governor Lachlan Macquarie. Macquarie saw the Indigenous People of Turtle Island (North America) wearing similar plates while serving in the British Army during the American War. Wanting to build relationships with Aboriginal people Macquarie formulated the idea to give Aboriginal Breastplates to individuals, usually with their name or some form of inscription to designate 'chiefs' despite Aboriginal people not having a chieftainship system.

Collectively, the many different inscriptions on breastplates tell a story of attempts at European domination and subjugation, through years of dispossession, indiscriminate slaughter, and martial law imposed on Aboriginal people. The issuing of breastplates was an attempt by non-Aboriginal Australians to impose their social order and cultural values on Aboriginal society, by holding recipients to a European way of thought and behavior (Kean 2016: 5).

The breastplate, a form of jewellery, is the physical marker of colonial actions. The object has not colonized; it has been used as a tool by its user to colonize. The object remains as a visual material marker of action, the action being ´the work´. The breastplate is a tool used in service to alter societal structures for a colonial project. An imposition of a system of control, a mastery system.

This mastery system filtered through capitalism, the constant drive for status and the reliance of the nation state which is beyond our control has maintained the desire to master or become a master. To have the ability to control something. When we buy something, it is perceived as being worth more if made or just said to have been crafted by a master whether it's a boat, a garden tool, lipstick or a meal cooked at a restaurant. It is a status symbol to not just keep up with the Joneses but to be the Joneses.



Fig. 6: Gabriel Metsu: *Weeping Woman in a Blacksmith's Shop*, n.d., Nationalmuseum, Sweden Attribution: Nationalmuseum Public Domain

Mastery in craft places a maker at a pinnacle, it comes with awards often given out by a representative organization of, or economically supported by, a nation state. It has also fueled individualism and distracted from craft's ability for human connection. In *Unthinking Mastery: Dehumanism and Decolonial Entanglements*, Julietta Singh unpacks that Mastery is a way to control something. To control it so tightly that it fractures.

There is an intimate link between the mastery enacted through colonization and other forms of mastery that we often believe today to be harmless, worthwhile, even virtuous. To be characterized as the master of a language, or a literary tradition, or an instrument, for instance, is widely understood to be laudable. Yet as a pursuit, mastery invariably and relentlessly reaches toward the indiscriminate control over something – whether human or inhuman, animate or inanimate. It aims for the full submission of an object – or

something objectified – whether it be external or internal to oneself. In so doing, mastery requires a rupturing of the object being mastered, because to be mastered means to be weakened to a point of fracture. (Singh 2018: 10).

I would propose that it is time to find a new word, one to mean the developing of an understanding that we will never fully control material or process but have a deep understanding of working, speaking and communicating with processes and materials which allows for a fluid relationship and ability to make shifts in working to avoid damage or unnecessary loss. Craft in this way becomes a citation through the hand, a way to pass on the knowledge we hold in our physical body. Knowledge inherited by those who have taught us with the implication to hold, grow and pass on this knowledge. In this way we are never crafting alone, the singular author dissipates. Craft connects us and places us in systems of kinship.

There is an importance to look beyond material and form specificity as parsed out by institutions. To position craft at large in a place of responsibility, for participating in building and in turn destroying worlds, past, present and possible. Craft has a relation to industrialization, nation state, and colonization, used to create health and harm. Craft when approached this way requires taking responsibility by acknowledging its use for where and how we got ourselves to this point in the world today. It summons the messy places most institutions want to keep under the rug. These include race, sex, gender, and anything else one can connect to a body. The body is not neutral in the constructed world we live in; it has been given a value based on shape, color, age, an ability or disability. A body is locatable on constructed maps, those defined by nation states, equatorial lines, money and power. Craft is a knowledge holding the possibility to dismantle and propose alternative systems of being.

As Audre Lorde famously wrote "The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house". But craft holds the language of tool making and therefore re-tooling. As Lewis R. Gordon and Jane Anna Gordon state in response to Lorde.

There are those who used those tools, developed additional ones, and built houses of their own on more or less generous soil. It is our view that the proper response is to follow their lead, transcending rather than dismantling Western ideas through building our own houses of thought. When enough houses are built, the hegemony of the master's house – in fact, mastery itself – will cease to maintain its imperial status. Shelter needn't be the room offered by such domination (2018: ix).

Craft is an act of service. It is just a matter of asking 'in service to what'? When visiting the Oconaluftee Indian Village In North Carolina U.S. I asked a Cherokee woman who was weaving what the word for craft was in the Cherokee language. She gave a brief smile and replied that there was no word for it, it was just what you did when you or someone else needed something. A service to fulfil a need, to craft something toward an easier and more comfortable life. And don't we all deserve comfort?

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